MODULE 06 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Leadership styles and servant leadership

Choosing a style that fits the person and the moment, leading without formal authority, and what 'servant leader' really asks of you.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 06 of 49

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The right leadership style is the one this person needs **right now**.

Management or leadership?

MANAGEMENT

Positional, about things

- Maintains control
- Focuses on systems and structure
- Relies on position and control
- Asks how and when

LEADERSHIP

Relational, about people

- Inspires trust
- Focuses on relationships
- Relies on influence
- Asks what and why

THE TIEBREAKER

Projects need both. But on this exam, when people are the problem, leadership behaviours win.

Common leadership styles

STYLE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	FITS WHEN
Directive	Leader decides and instructs	Crisis, safety, or someone brand new to a task
Participative	Leader involves the team in decisions	Buy-in matters and time allows
Delegating	Team decides within agreed boundaries	Skilled, motivated, experienced people
Transactional	Rewards and corrections tied to targets	Routine work with clear standards
Transformational	Inspires through vision and growth	Change, innovation, long engagements
Servant	Serves the team so it can perform	The default for agile teams, and most exam answers

ON THE EXAM

Every style has a place. The exam's default is servant leadership, shifted by the situation.

Transactional or transformational?

TRANSACTIONAL

Exchange

- Clear targets and rewards
- Corrects deviations
- Keeps things running
- Motivation from outside

TRANSFORMATIONAL

Inspiration

- A compelling shared vision
- Develops each person
- Encourages new thinking
- Motivation from within

THE TIEBREAKER

Transactional keeps a stable system running. Transformational changes what people believe is possible.

Situational leadership: match style to readiness

THE PERSON IS...	THEY NEED	STYLE
New to the task, but keen	Clear instructions and close guidance	Directing
Learning, and losing confidence	Direction plus encouragement	Coaching
Skilled, but hesitant or unsure	Support and shared decisions	Supporting
Skilled and confident	Freedom and trust	Delegating

ON THE EXAM

Readiness is per task, not per person. An expert in one area can be a beginner in another.

Reading readiness from a scenario

- 'Recently joined', 'first time', 'enthusiastic but unfamiliar': guide closely, with clear steps.
- 'Making mistakes', 'frustrated', 'starting to doubt': explain, encourage, stay close.
- 'Experienced but reluctant', 'capable, lacks confidence': involve them, reassure, share the decision.
- 'Expert', 'has done this many times': delegate, and stay available.
- Delegating to a beginner feels respectful. It is actually abandonment.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The planted detail is usually one adjective about the person. Read it before choosing a style.

The leader exists to help the team succeed, **not the other way round**.

What a servant leader actually does

- **Removes impediments** the team cannot remove itself: approvals, access, missing people.
- **Shields the team** from interruptions and conflicting demands.
- **Communicates the vision** again and again, so decisions stay aligned.
- **Provides what the team needs** to work: tools, information, a good environment.
- **Grows people** through coaching, listening and opportunities.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Every item on this list is active. A servant leader is busy, just not busy directing the work.

Servant leadership or laissez-faire?

SERVANT LEADERSHIP

Present and working

- Clears the path actively
- Sets boundaries and a vision
- Checks in and coaches
- Steps in when the team is stuck

LAISSEZ-FAIRE

Absent

- Leaves the team alone
- No boundaries or vision
- Waits to be asked
- Lets problems grow

THE TIEBREAKER

'Let the team handle it' is right only when the team can handle it and you are still supporting them.

Where a project manager's power comes from

POWER	COMES FROM	ON THE EXAM
Formal, or legitimate	Your role and title	Real, but often limited for a PM
Reward	Ability to give something valued	Useful; only if genuinely yours to give
Coercive	Ability to penalise	Almost always the wrong answer
Expert	Knowledge and skill	Strong and durable
Referent	Trust, respect and relationships	Strong and durable
Informational	Access to information others need	Useful; never hoard it

ON THE EXAM

Expert and referent power last longest. Coercive power buys compliance and costs trust.

Leading without authority

- In a **matrix organisation**, team members often report to functional managers, not to you.
- Build relationships early, before you need anything from anyone.
- Negotiate priorities **with the functional manager**, not around them.
- Show people how the project helps their own goals and growth.
- Threats, going over people's heads, and promises you cannot keep all backfire.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Influence is built before it is needed. Use relationships and expertise, and work with line managers.

Empowerment: agree who decides

LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS	EXAMPLE
Tell	The leader decides and explains	A regulatory deadline that cannot move
Consult	The leader decides after asking the team	Choosing a supplier with team input
Agree	The leader and team decide together	The team's working agreement
Delegate	The team decides, within boundaries	How to build a feature; which tool to use

ON THE EXAM

Empowerment is not giving away every decision. It is being clear about who decides what, and why.

Setting expectations at team level

- Agree **outcomes and standards**, not minute-by-minute tasks.
- Make **roles and decision rights** clear from the start. Module 07 covers how.
- Create a **working agreement** with the team, so norms are shared, not imposed.
- Revisit expectations when the team, the work or the approach changes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Many 'people problems' in scenarios are really unclear expectations. Clarify before you correct.

Be an accountable leader

- A PMBOK 8 principle: own **outcomes**, not just activity.
- You can delegate **authority and tasks**. You cannot delegate your accountability.
- When something goes wrong, take responsibility outwards, then fix the cause with the team privately.
- Blaming a team member in front of stakeholders destroys trust and solves nothing.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Credit goes to the team in public. Accountability stays with you.

Represent the voice of the team

- Carry the team's concerns upward: unrealistic dates, missing resources, unclear direction.
- Bring **evidence and options**, such as velocity data and scope trade-offs, not complaints.
- Report back honestly, including when the answer is no.
- Silently accepting an impossible demand is not loyalty. It sets the team up to fail.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Advocacy with data and options is leadership. Passing the pressure straight down is not.

Leadership across approaches and moments

- **Agile teams**: servant leadership by default; the team owns how work is done.
- **Predictive work**: more coordination and planning, still delivered through people, not orders.
- **Hybrid**: both at once, often in the same week, for different workstreams.
- **Crisis or safety risk**: act directively and immediately, then return to your usual style.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Safety overrides style. When people could be hurt, act first and consult afterwards.

Project Lantern: three people, three styles

- A **new clinic coordinator**, keen but new to go-live checklists: direct, with clear steps and close support.
- A **senior developer** who has built booking systems before: delegate, and stay available.
- The **kiosk supplier's engineer**, who does not report to you at all: influence through relationship and shared goals.
- Same project manager, same week. Style follows the person and the task.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> One leader, several styles in the same week. That flexibility is what the exam is testing.

Scenario signals and the leadership move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
New team member, first time on this task	Direct: clear steps, close guidance
Team constantly interrupted by outside requests	Shield: route requests through the right channel
Team member ignores the PM, reports to someone else	Influence: relationship, and agree priorities with their manager
Team asks the PM to make a technical choice	Empower: facilitate their decision within constraints
Management imposes an impossible date	Advocate: evidence and options, upward
Someone could be injured	Act directively, now

ON THE EXAM

Match the move to the signal. Most leadership questions reduce to one of these six.

> A recent graduate joins a testing team and is excited about the project. She has never written automated test scripts before, and her first scripts are due next week.
>
> Other team members are experienced and working independently.

Which approach should the project manager take with the graduate?

A Delegate the scripts fully, to show trust in her abilities.

B Give clear instructions and close guidance, then reduce it as her skill grows.

C Share decisions with her and offer encouragement, as with a capable colleague.

D Leave her to learn from the other testers as they work.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach should the project manager take with the graduate?

A Delegate fully.

Right for an expert. For a beginner it is abandonment, however kindly meant.

B Clear instructions, close guidance, then reduce.

High commitment, low competence on this task: directing, then moving on.

C Share decisions, encourage.

The supporting style, for someone skilled but hesitant. She lacks the skill, not the confidence.

D Learn from the others.

Laissez-faire. Nobody is accountable for her learning, and the deadline is next week.

THE SIGNAL

Keen but new to the task: direct now, and plan to step back as competence grows.

> An agile team's work keeps being interrupted by a finance department head, who asks developers directly for urgent report changes.
>
> The developers feel they cannot refuse someone so senior, and the team missed its last two iteration goals.

What should the project leader do?

A Tell the developers to refuse any request that does not come from the product owner.

B Accept the requests, because the department head outranks the product owner.

C Escalate the department head's behaviour to the sponsor.

D Meet the department head to understand the needs, and agree that requests go through the product owner.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Developers refuse.

Pushes a senior conflict onto junior people. The leader should shield them.

B Accept, because of seniority.

Seniority does not change who owns priorities, and the team keeps failing.

C Escalate to the sponsor.

Nobody has spoken to the department head yet. Too early.

D Meet, understand, agree the channel.

Shields the team and still meets the head's real needs through the backlog.

THE SIGNAL

The team is being pulled in several directions. The servant leader shields it, by talking to the source.

> In a matrix organisation, three engineers assigned to a project keep prioritising work for their functional manager. Project tasks slip each week.
>
> The project manager has no formal authority over the engineers or their appraisals.

What is the best way for the project manager to gain the engineers' commitment?

A Build relationships with the engineers, and agree project priorities with their functional manager.

B Warn the engineers that their project performance will be reported negatively.

C Promise the engineers bonuses if project tasks finish on time.

D Ask the sponsor to order the engineers to put the project first.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best way for the project manager to gain the engineers' commitment?

A Relationships, and agree priorities with their manager.

Referent power plus working with the line manager: fixes the real conflict of priorities.

B Warn of negative reports.

Coercive, and not even the PM's power to use. It buys resentment.

C Promise bonuses.

A reward the PM does not control. A promise that cannot be kept destroys trust.

D Sponsor orders them.

Goes over the functional manager's head before talking to them.

THE SIGNAL

No formal authority: use relationships and expertise, and settle priorities with the line manager.

> A self-organising team must choose between two test automation tools. Both meet the organisation's security and budget rules.
>
> The team is split, and asks the project manager to make the choice for them.

What should the project manager do?

A Choose the cheaper tool, to protect the budget.

B Ask the sponsor to decide, since it is a spending decision.

C Facilitate a team decision, confirming the constraints and a way to decide.

D Let the most senior developer choose.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Choose the cheaper one.

Both already fit the budget. Takes a decision that belongs to the team.

B Ask the sponsor.

Escalates a decision already inside agreed limits.

C Facilitate the team's decision.

Empowers the team, which will use the tool daily, within clear boundaries.

D Senior developer chooses.

Creates a hierarchy inside a self-organising team and sidelines the others.

THE SIGNAL

Inside the boundaries, the team decides. The leader's job is to help it decide well, not to decide for it.

> A defect in a release the project manager approved has caused incorrect invoices for several customers. The sponsor is angry.
>
> In a meeting with senior stakeholders, the sponsor asks the project manager who is responsible.

How should the project manager respond?

A Name the developer who wrote the faulty code, so the sponsor knows where the problem lies.

B Take responsibility, explain the corrective plan, then work on the root cause with the team privately.

C Explain that the quality assurance team should have caught the defect.

D Point out that the requirements from the business were unclear.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the project manager respond?

A. Name the developer.
Public blame destroys trust, and the PM approved the release.

B. Own it, give the plan, fix the cause privately.
Accountable leadership: responsibility outward, root cause inward.

C. Blame the QA team.
Shifts blame to another group. Still not accountability.

D. Blame unclear requirements.
Blames the business in front of the business. Defensive, and it fixes nothing.

THE SIGNAL

The project manager approved the release. Accountability cannot be delegated downwards.

> Senior management moves a product launch six weeks earlier without consulting the team. The team's measured velocity shows the planned scope cannot be finished by the new date.
>
> The team is demoralised and asks the project manager to push back.

What should the project manager do?

A Ask the team to work extra hours to meet the new date.

B Accept the date and reduce testing to fit the time available.

C Tell management that the new date is impossible.

D Work with the team on options, such as reduced scope, and present them to management with the velocity data.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Extra hours.

Overtime was never a winning answer in the bank. Unsustainable, and burns the team.

B Cut testing.

Trades hidden quality risk for a date. Quality is not a silent variable.

C Say it is impossible.

Right about the facts, but gives management nothing to decide with.

D Options and data, presented upward.

Represents the team with evidence, and gives management a real choice.

THE SIGNAL

Advocate upward with evidence and options. Neither absorb the pressure nor simply refuse.

Read the person, pick the style, **serve** the team, and own the outcome.